

Module 3: Religion, Ethics, and Migration

Graduate Research Project

Ethics at the Border of Policy: Religious Actors in a Contemporary Migration Debate

Overview

A research paper critically evaluating how competing ethical frameworks and religious actors have shaped one contemporary migration policy debate (e.g., sanctuary policies, asylum caps, border externalization).

Aligned learning outcomes

- Critically evaluate ethical frameworks (Grad 1)
- Apply frameworks to policy debates (Grad 2)

Sample research questions

- How do consequentialist, rights-based, and theological arguments collide in your chosen debate?
- When religious institutions intervene (e.g., sanctuary movement, papal statements), what ethical framework are they operationalizing?
- Which arguments actually moved policy, and which remained rhetorical?

Methods

Framework-based documentary analysis: policy documents, religious statements, advocacy materials, and scholarship. Optional 1–2 expert interviews with clergy or advocates.

IRB / research ethics

Required only if conducting interviews; consult your IRB for expedited review. Documentary-only versions need no review.

Deliverables

- 4,000–5,000-word analytical paper
- 800-word public commentary (op-ed style) translating the analysis for a general audience

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Sophistication of ethical framework application 35%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: sophistication of ethical framework application goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: sophistication of ethical framework application is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: sophistication of ethical framework application is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: sophistication of ethical framework application is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Evidence base and fairness to opposing views 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: evidence base and fairness to opposing views is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: evidence base and fairness to opposing views is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: evidence base and fairness to opposing views is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: evidence base and fairness to opposing views is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Analytical originality 20%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: analytical originality goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: analytical originality is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: analytical originality is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: analytical originality is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Quality of the public commentary 15%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: quality of the public commentary goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: quality of the public commentary is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: quality of the public commentary is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: quality of the public commentary is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.